Legacy agreements were electrified, such as the GE F414 Engine agreement with Hindustan Aeronautics Limited. The American defence 'prime' General Atomics used the energy driven by iCET to return to the sale of MQ-9B HALE Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs) to India. Both agreements are being currently negotiated.

A canvas has been drawn: From investments in semiconductors to creating a new strategic technology ecosystem, with active participation from innovators, investors, industrialists and governments, iCET has got off to a more-than-an-impressive start. Following this playbook, in July 2024, the United Kingdom and India entered into a Technology Security Initiative (TSI). This, too, is coordinated by the respective NSAs. The agenda is narrower and focused. It includes cross-cutting areas such as telecom, critical minerals, AI, quantum technologies and biotechnology. From hackathons to bridges for knowledge-sharing, there is a lot in TSI that, for excellent reason, crosses paths with iCET. This could, in time, support triangular co-operation in some areas between the three countries.

There is no doubt that the Indian leadership has responded with an equal dose of stratagem and tact to the imperatives of a fast-changing world, in at least architecting strategic frameworks for deeper partnerships. This is as much about accessing critical technologies, co-innovating, as it is about incubating new manufacturing and assembly hubs in India. These partnerships could accelerate the ongoing drive to diversify military supplies and shape a future that strikes a near-right balance between nourishing self-reliance and amplifying co-production.

A canvas has been drawn. Industrialists, geeks, coders, export controllers, regulators and continued top-level political leadership will need to drive success over the next many years. Several countries, especially in Asia, are knocking on India's doors for similar arrangements. To be sure, at least three of the six working groups of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) between India, Australia, Japan and the US, which pre-date iCET and TSI, are dedicated to different aspects of technology cooperation.

"Can India arrest the potential that screams out of the various 'fact sheets' and read-outs that inform partnerships such as these?" is the common refrain amongst detractors and believers alike. To me, the answer is a clear yes. On iCET and aspects of Quad, there is enough evidence to suggest that the initiatives are delivering. Yet, as India enters its 78th year of Independence, and with the view to unlock its own potential, what is needed is an administrative pivot to maximise the possibilities in these less-usual strategic partnerships. Reimagining and re-energising the bureaucratic machine that sometimes sits in silos across New Delhi should be as much of a strategic priority as pumping further funds into strategic incentive schemes and signing new defence agreements. Speak to those who have been there and done it, "getting the bureaucracy right" is an old and tiring song that never stops playing in the background. That might be so. But it does not take away from the need for change.

THE GIANT STEPS

- **Harness the potential in areas like space, defence and semiconductors with strategic tech partnerships along the lines of the US–India iCET**
- **Establish a new cadre of technology envoys to coordinate efforts across different government agencies**
- **Retain institutional knowledge by nurturing officials who have shaped these partnerships, rather than losing their expertise**

Getting the bureaucracy right: The Indian government could consider a new cadre of technology envoys. Many countries have these to good effect. We do not. Envoys need to coordinate. A Special Envoy, potentially in the MEA, could work alongside the NSCS in delivering results. This is just one formula. There will be many. The moot point is about the urgent need for coordinated action and to actively synthesise different lines of effort. Critical technology is transformative and cuts across departments and ministries alike. Those shaping these efforts will need an adaptive structure.

Further, there is plenty of institutional knowledge amongst officials who have shaped different aspects of a partnership process. As is the practice, for their own administrative futures, they typically move on. These are exactly the kind of people who ought to be nurtured to be part of teams or divisions engaged in the business of iCET, TSI, Quad and other agreements in the offing. The knowledge they possess should be reused, not rebuilt. At the apex of bureaucratic structures, the government has made many effective decisions for continuity. There is a need to expand this verve to different levels of the 'system'.

In sum, there is a need for a call for action that is managerially nuanced and creatively structured. The opportunity cost of not pivoting to new administrative realities could be discriminatingly high for a country that is poised to shape the future of the world—in one way or another. ■

The author is Director, Carnegie India. Views are personal